

THE BUSINESS STARTER GUIDE

Prepare before you build

A practical guide for business owners

Prepare your business for a digital presence

Core message • Content and images • Mistakes to avoid

Examples, visual explanations and worksheets for your website, landing page or campaign.



Illustrative image created with AI

START HERE

How to use this guide

Read, decide, write and check - in that order.

This guide is for business owners preparing a new digital presence or planning an update. It covers preparation: you do not need to choose a website platform or launch a campaign to complete it.

Work on one offer

Choose one service or product for the exercises. Trying to write a message for every part of the business at once makes it harder to identify what matters. Repeat the process for other offers later.

Keep one working document

Print the worksheets or copy the questions into a document. Write a first answer even if it is imperfect. Mark missing information and name the person who will provide it.

Our running example

Home in Order is a fictional home-organising business helping families prepare for a move. All names, sample copy and illustrations are for learning purposes, not real client results or testimonials.

Your route through the guide

Pages 3-4: Choose a goal and understand your audience.

Pages 5-8: Build and practise your core message.

Pages 9-13: Prepare copy, images and your content pack.

Pages 14-16: Plan your page and avoid common mistakes.

Pages 17-18: Complete your brief and readiness checklist.

STEP 01 • GOAL

What should happen next?

Choose one business action before choosing colours and images.

“I need a website” describes a tool. “I want people in my service area to request a consultation” describes a goal. That goal shapes the content, page structure and way you handle enquiries.

Business website

Useful when visitors need to explore several services, learn about you and view your work. For example, a business may offer home organising, moving preparation and office organising, each with different details.

Landing page

Useful for a focused offer and a defined audience. For example, a moving-preparation page with a service explanation, a work example and a consultation button. A page within a larger website can serve this purpose too.

Campaign

Advertising brings people to an offer. Before you advertise, prepare a destination and a process for handling responses. The page, call or form should continue the promise made in the advertisement.

Example decision

Goal: consultation requests for pre-move organising. Main action: submit contact details. Owner: the business owner. Review measure: how many enquiries suited the service and progressed to a conversation.

Write your decision

What single action should a visitor take? Who receives it? How quickly can your business realistically respond? Choose an achievable internal response target; do not promise a turnaround you cannot meet.

STEP 02 • AUDIENCE

Who are you speaking to?

A clear audience helps you choose useful words, images and details.

“Everyone” is not a useful writing brief. Start with the customer’s situation: what has happened, what they are trying to solve and what makes them hesitate. Age and location can help, but do not replace understanding the need.

1. The situation that starts the search

In our example: a family is moving soon, has many belongings and little time. They need help sorting and preparing, which is not necessarily the same as cleaning or transportation.

2. The difficulty in their own words

Use language people use when contacting you, such as “We do not know where to start.” Review genuine enquiries and notes from previous conversations without publishing personal information.

3. The question holding them back

Must they prepare anything? Does the service include packing? Which areas do you cover? Address important questions before asking visitors to submit their details.

My audience is in this situation:

They want to achieve / are concerned about:

The most important question I must answer:

STEP 03 • MESSAGE

Build your core message

Who gets what, how you help and why your offer is credible.

Your core message is the idea you want visitors to remember. It is not a list of everything you sell. Start with a longer working sentence, then shorten it into a headline and a supporting line.

A formula to practise

We help [a specific audience] work towards [a desired outcome] through [a clear service], with [a real, relevant characteristic].

Audience and outcome

“Families preparing to move” identifies an audience. “Reach moving day with belongings sorted” gives a concrete outcome. Avoid guaranteeing results that depend on factors outside your control.

Service and difference

“Sorting and organising in your home” explains the activity. “We start with one area based on your priorities” describes the method. A characteristic is useful only if it accurately reflects the service you provide.

A reason to believe

Genuine work photos, an explained process, relevant qualifications or an approved testimonial can support your message. If you have no evidence yet, explain the process and its limits. Never invent experience or clients.

Check for clarity

Read your message aloud. Can someone unfamiliar with your business explain what you offer? Could any competitor use your sentence unchanged? Replace generic claims with a specific fact about your service.

STEP 04 • EXAMPLE

Turn a slogan into an offer

An editing example, not a claim about sales or performance.

Too general

“Advanced solutions with uncompromising quality. Professionalism, reliability and personal service. Click here for details.”

The wording sounds positive, but does not say what the service is, who it suits or what happens after the click. The visitor has to fill in the missing information.

Suggested headline

“Moving home? Start with sorting and a plan.”

Suggested supporting line

“Home sorting and organising for families preparing to move: decide what stays, work through each area and make a plan for what comes next.”

Suggested action

“Request a consultation”

What belongs beside the offer?

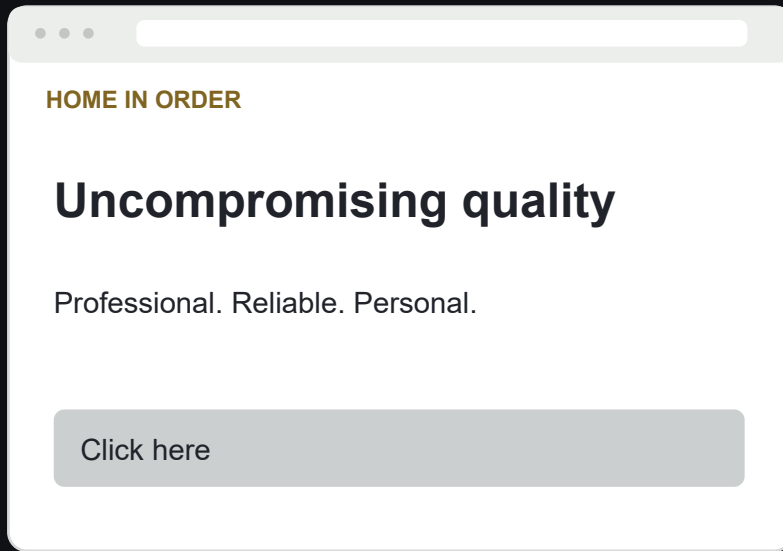
State your actual service area, what a session includes and what it excludes. If you do not provide packing or transportation, make that clear. If pricing follows a discussion, explain what you need to prepare a quote.

Use the same offer in the advertisement, on the page and in the conversation. If the ad promises pre-move organising, the destination headline should confirm that service.

VISUAL EXAMPLE

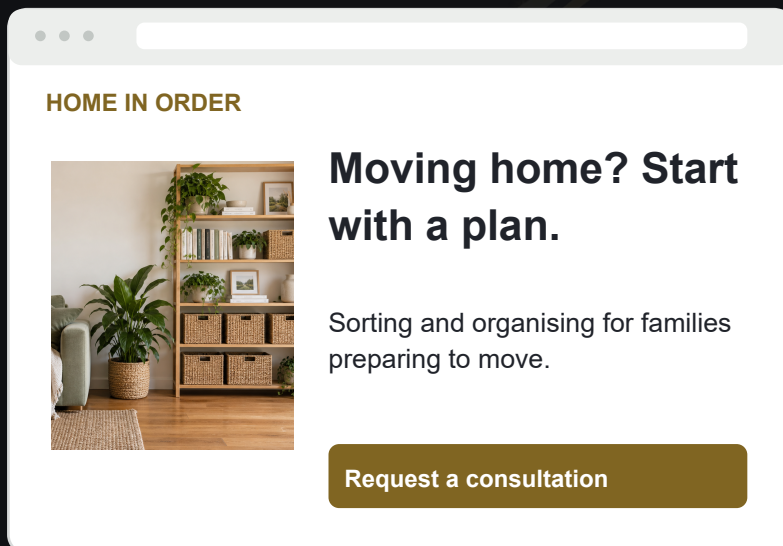
See the message at work

Example: a home-organising business helping families move.



1 Before: what is offered?

A broad claim leaves the service and audience unclear.



2 After: a specific offer

The headline names the situation. The copy explains the service and audience. The button names the next step.

Mock page for a fictional business. The change illustrates clarity, not a promise of higher sales.

WORKSHEET 01

Your message, in your words

Complete your first draft, then make it shorter and clearer.

The main service or product I offer:

Who it suits and their situation:

The outcome the service works towards:

A genuine characteristic of the way I work:

A headline that makes the offer clear:

Supporting line: what people get and need to know:

The desired action and the button wording:

Peer check: show the headline and supporting line to someone unfamiliar with your business. Ask what is offered and what the next step is. If their answer differs from your intention, revise the wording.

STEP 05 • COPY

What materials do you need?

A structured document reduces questions during the build.

Business and contact details

Prepare the display name, contact person, phone, email, service area, opening hours and links to active channels. Make sure someone actually receives messages through every channel you display.

A description of each service

Explain who it suits, the problem it addresses, what is included, what is excluded, how to begin and what information the customer must provide. Use an approved price or explain how a quote is prepared.

A focused introduction

Explain who runs the business, their relevant experience and how they work. Choose specific facts over broad labels. You do not need a long life story to help visitors feel familiar with you.

Questions and answers

Answer five recurring customer questions. Examples include service areas, advance preparation, the process, inclusions and booking. Do not add answers merely to fill space.

Credible supporting evidence

Collect publishable work examples, approved testimonials, original photos and relevant qualifications. Record the source and permission to use each item. Do not present a stock illustration as your own work.

A simple way to begin

Create a document using the five headings on this page. Under each, record: ready / missing / person responsible. Provide editable copy rather than screenshots of text messages.

STEP 06 • IMAGES

Images that explain your work

Choose each image for its role, not just its appearance.

Opening image

Support the service and mood. For our example, use an organised home area with space beside the subject for a headline. Check that a narrow mobile crop does not remove the important part.

Process and result

Show steps or details that explain the work. For before-and-after comparisons, keep the angle and lighting as consistent as possible so the comparison is understandable and not misleading.

People and trust

A natural photo of the owner or team can show who provides the service. Publish only materials you have permission to use. Avoid exposing client addresses, documents or other personal details.

An example shot list

A wide view of an organised area; a portrait-format image of that area; a close-up of the organising method; a photo of the owner; and an image of work in progress. This is a planning example, not a requirement for every business.

What should you hand over?

Provide good-quality original files, a short description of each photo and its intended use. Ask for lightweight website versions and checks on desktop and mobile. Keep originals separately; enlarging a blurry image does not restore detail.

Do not place essential wording only inside an image. Supply headlines and service details as text too, so they can be read, edited and adapted to different screens.

VISUAL EXAMPLE

Plan the image crop

Home-organising example: crop a service image for two screens.

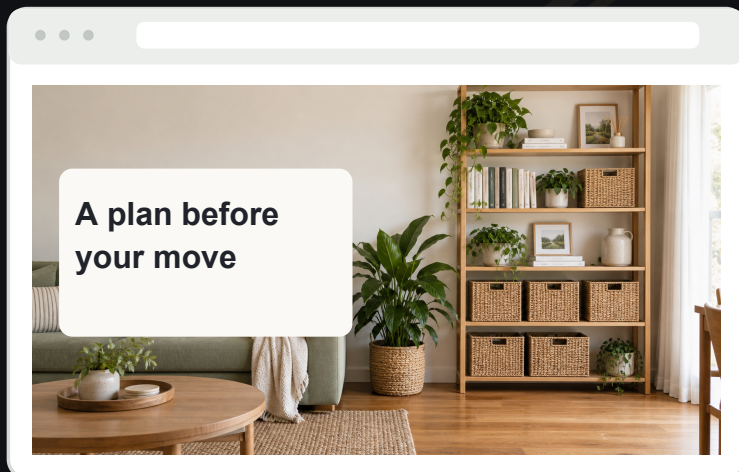
One image, two screens



1

Space for a headline

2



A plan before
your move

1

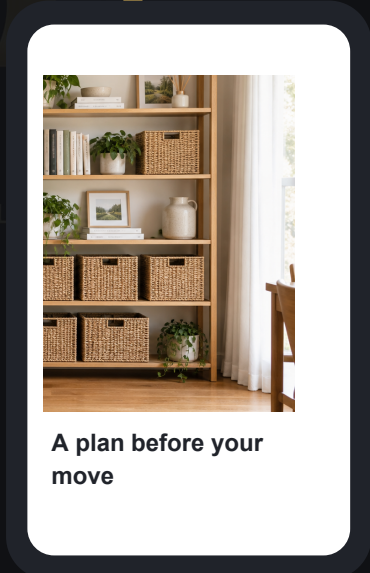
Desktop: wide image

Leave room for copy without hiding the subject.

2

Mobile: focused crop

Keep the shelving inside the frame.



A plan before your
move

AI-generated illustrative photo. Test narrow screens and preserve the important detail by cropping, not stretching.

WORKSHEET 02

Organise your content pack

One place for files, with owners and completion dates.

Example folder structure

01 Business details • 02 Copy • 03 Logo • 04 Original photos • 05 Testimonials and permissions • 06 Approved brief

Use descriptive filenames, such as “kitchen-organising-after”. For each item, record the subject, source, publication approval and intended page. Select one approved version of each piece of copy.

Materials that are already ready:

Missing materials and the person responsible for each:

Photos or testimonials still awaiting approval:

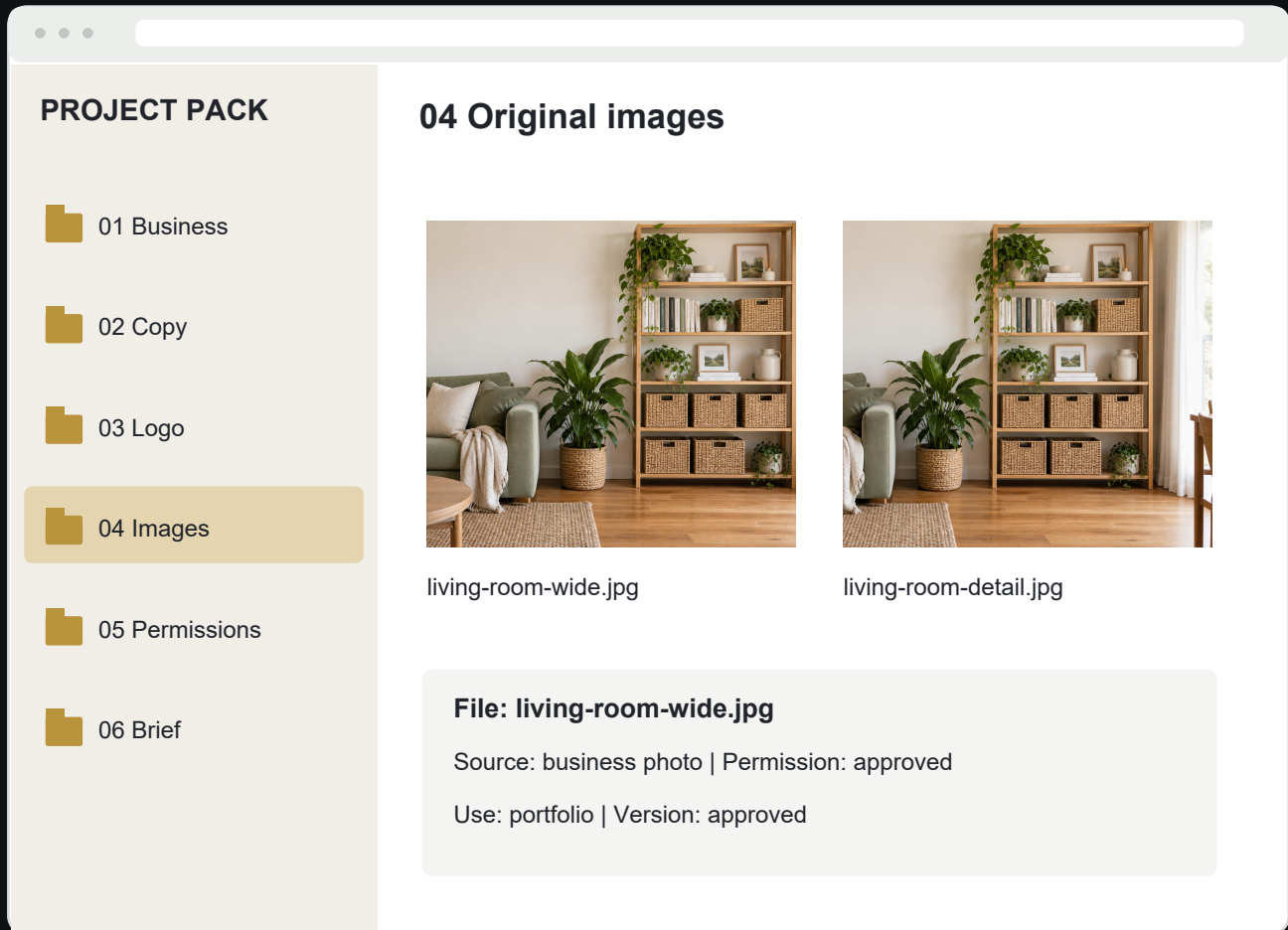
Handover date and the person approving the materials:

For domains, hosting and business accounts, record who owns and manages each service. Share access using the service's appropriate method, not a list of passwords inside your content folder.

VISUAL EXAMPLE

A content pack in practice

A visual example of files, folders and asset details.



1 Descriptive filenames

A descriptive name makes each file easy to find and identify.

2 Details beside every asset

Record source, permission and intended use. The entries shown here are illustrative only.

A folder mockup, not a screenshot of a particular application. Photos are AI-generated examples, not real client work.

STEP 07 • PAGE PLAN

What does a visitor need to see?

A schematic landing-page plan, not a mandatory template.

01 Opening

Clear headline + short explanation + main action

02 The offer

What is included, who it suits and its limits

03 Credibility

Genuine work, approved feedback or an explained process

04 The process

Enquiry, discussion and the next service step

05 Questions and action

Answers to concerns + contact form or button

How to use this plan

Match your prepared materials to each section. If a section lacks genuine content, mark it for completion or adapt the structure. You can repeat the same main action down the page, as long as its destination is clear.

For a website with several services, split information into pages where useful. Before advertising, check that the advertisement, page and follow-up response describe the same offer.

VISUAL EXAMPLE

A page with a clear purpose

A designed example with notes beside each section.

HOME IN ORDER



Moving home? Start with a plan.

Pre-move sorting and organising

Request a consultation

What is included?

Sorting belongings • Organising by area • A next-step plan

Our process

Consult

Organise

Plan ahead

A look at the work



Explain the method and show genuine work.

Does this include transport?

No. This service focuses on sorting and organising.

Request a consultation

1 Clear offer

Who it is for, what you offer and what to do next.

2 Scope and limits

Explain what is included; do not leave visitors guessing.

3 Process and trust

Show how you work and add genuine evidence.

4 Questions and action

Address hesitation and repeat the same main action.

Designed example for a fictional business. Adapt the structure; do not copy service details that do not apply to you.

STEP 08 • AVOIDABLE MISTAKES

Six mistakes to prevent

An early check reduces confusion and revisions later.

1. Designing before the offer is clear

Result: an attractive page visitors struggle to understand. Instead, approve the headline, service description and main action before choosing the layout and images.

2. Speaking to everyone at once

Result: a generic list of benefits. Instead, choose one audience and situation for each offer. Separate services when their customer needs differ.

3. Making unsupported promises

Result: a gap between expectations and delivery. Instead, explain what you actually do and use genuine evidence. Never invent testimonials, success figures or client photos.

4. Competing actions everywhere

Result: visitors cannot tell what to do first. Instead, choose a primary action and give other options lower priority where they are needed.

5. Handing over incomplete materials

Result: repeated questions and conflicting versions. Instead, provide an approved folder and document, with a list of gaps and a named owner for each missing item.

6. Advertising before testing enquiries

Result: enquiries may be lost. Instead, send a test enquiry from a phone, confirm it arrives and make sure someone knows how to handle it.

WORKSHEET 03

Your handover brief

A decision summary to share with the person doing the work.

Business name, contact person and final approver:

What we are building, for whom and the main goal:

The offer, core message and desired action:

What must be included and what is outside the project:

Content folder link and outstanding materials:

Budget range, target date and unresolved dependencies:

Who receives enquiries and how we will test the route:

This brief starts the planning conversation. Agree the scope, responsibilities, deliverables and change-approval process separately with the person carrying out the work.

FINISH WITH A PLAN

Ready for the next step?

Review the list and identify what is complete or still missing.

- ☐ I chose one main service or product.
- ☐ I defined an audience, need and key customer question.
- ☐ My headline and explanation make sense to an outsider.
- ☐ I chose a main action and an owner for incoming enquiries.
- ☐ I described what the service includes and excludes.
- ☐ I collected suitable images and usage-permission details.
- ☐ I prepared genuine evidence or a clear process description.
- ☐ I organised my content pack and assigned missing items.
- ☐ I completed a brief with a budget range and target date.

If something is still missing

Resolve the message, service scope and enquiry process before work begins. Supporting materials can be scheduled if ownership and timing are clear. Do not replace missing information with unsupported promises.

Before publishing or advertising

Check mobile readability, links, forms and receipt of enquiries. Arrange the privacy, accessibility and measurement checks relevant to your project. This guide prepares your content and brief; it does not cover every launch check.

Your next action: take the brief and content pack to a planning conversation and leave with an agreed scope of work.

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